



“Over the last few years, a lot of companies have consciously worked towards hiring women in core sectors”

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THE INDIAN WAY

The approach for multinational companies is also determined by what the parent does globally. For Siemens, the gender equity programme unveiled globally in 2021 focussed on women's representation at all levels and to also create a strong foundation of leaders. In India, too, the aim is to increase diversity in hiring. Maheshwari says they are “actively encouraged” to break any bias and reimagine, rethink, and realign stereotypes.

At carmaker Mercedes-Benz India, every second hire is a woman, says MD & CEO Santosh Iyer. “We have doubled the number of women in the past decade. The commitment made by Mercedes-Benz is to have 30% women in senior management positions worldwide by 2030. It's a strategic move towards realising the full potential of our diverse workforce,” he says.

Again, the job description varies across organisations. Iyer says the women in his company handle complex functions on the shop floor with a TAKT time (a manufac-

turing term that describes the rate at which a product is made to meet customer demand) of 15+ minutes, which includes the assembly process, updating reports, and analysing efficacies.

“Our manufacturing women workforce get global exposure since they support the CKD (completely knocked down) network across six plants in Asia. They manage all end-to-end vendor and supplier relations from negotiation to implementation and ensure cost optimisation,” says Iyer. Among the top positions at Mercedes-Benz India occupied by women are the CFO, CIO and head of data analytics.

Tata Steel's Sanyal speaks of research done in mines out of South Africa and Australia where women operate heavy equipment leading to an increase in productivity. “It is perhaps right to say that women inherently have a better eye for detail and better time management since they need to deal with issues at home as well,” she says.

ABB's Singh highlights how his company has an all-women team at

the forefront of its remote monitoring centre, or a production line run completely by women. “The IoT implementation in our smart power factory is managed by a woman leader and her team,” he says.

Iyer points to the competitive landscape, where diverse leadership is recognised as a business imperative. “Those that champion it are more likely to attract and retain top talent, build a culture of innovation, and most likely outperform its competitors,” he says. In 2006, Mercedes-Benz globally set itself a target of increasing the share of women in senior management positions to 20% by 2020. That share stands at 26% today. Quite obviously, a lot has changed but this journey has barely started.

Technology will continue to be that pivot enabling greater participation of women in the core sectors. And with the increasing use of technology in these sectors, one can expect the number of women to keep rising. **BT**

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